

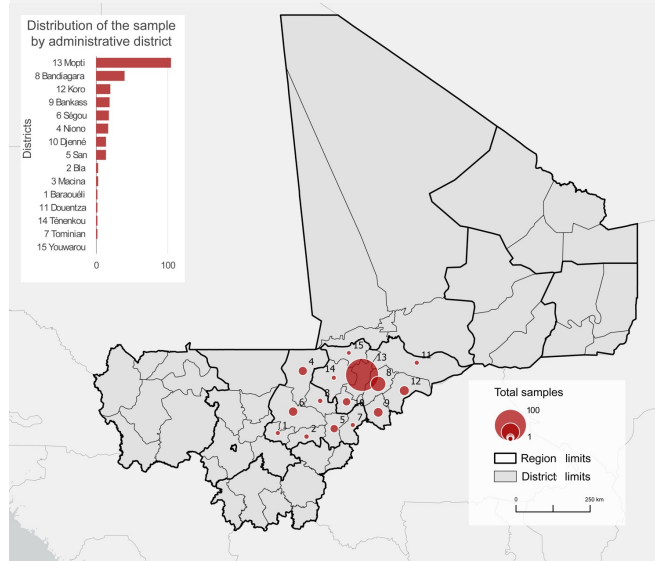


Key highlights

- In October and November 2025, the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations (FAO) conducted a computer-assisted telephone interview (CATI) survey under its Data in Emergencies Monitoring (DIEM-Monitoring) initiative, reaching 247 internally displaced households in the Mopti and Ségou regions of Mali. The survey aimed to identify the impact of displacement on agricultural activities, food security and the needs of these populations.
- As at September 2025, the Mopti and Ségou regions were the first and third regions¹ in terms of hosting internally displaced persons (IDPs) in the country. Forty-eight percent of all IDPs in Mali are located in these regions (IOM, 2025).
- Displacement significantly reduces engagement in agricultural activities: 56 percent of households that practiced agriculture before their displacement ceased agricultural production activities. The proportion of households engaged in agricultural production fell from 94 percent before displacement to 41 percent after.
- Despite this decline, agriculture remains central to the livelihoods of displaced populations: 60 percent of households depend on the sector after displacement, either through their own production (41 percent) or through agricultural wage labour and trade (19 percent).
- Access to land and water is the main obstacle to resuming agricultural activities – reported by 50 percent of households engaged in agricultural production before displacement. The high cost of renting or buying land (40 percent), limited availability (32 percent), insecurity (24 percent) and restrictions imposed by authorities (14 percent) were additional obstacles cited. Among displaced households that have not resumed agricultural activities, 73 percent have no access to land.
- Food insecurity among internally displaced households is high: among the 40 percent who have inadequate food consumption, 23 percent are experiencing acute food insecurity and require assistance, while 99 percent report needing assistance within six months following the survey.

¹ Administrative regions before the 2023 territorial reform.

Figure 1. Geographical coverage of the sample



Note: Refer to the disclaimer on the last page for the names and boundaries used in this map.

Source: FAO. 2026. DIEM-Monitoring. In: *DIEM Hub*. Rome.

[Cited 6 April 2026]. <https://data-in-emergencies.fao.org/pages/monitoring>

- Assistance programmes should combine food assistance and support for agricultural livelihoods, while integrating mechanisms that facilitate access to land and water. They should also include options tailored to households without access to land, such as agricultural labour and income-generating agricultural activities.

Context

Since the onset of the security crisis in the north of Mali in 2012 – Gao, Kidal and Tombouctou regions – Mali has experienced massive and prolonged internal displacement. Since 2018, the central regions (Mopti and Ségou) have been impacted. The impact of conflict and insecurity has more recently spread to the southern and western regions – Kayes, Koulikoro and the outskirts of Bamako – and the tri-border area – Ménaka.

In September 2025, the number of IDPs reached 414 524, concentrated in the regions of Bandiagara, Gao, Ménaka, Mopti, Ségou and Tombouctou. Most of the IDPs live

among host communities or in camps. Displacement dynamics remain active and complex: 12 357 new IDPs were recorded between January and September 2025. However, there have also been return movements and more than 875 000 IDPs returned between 2013 and 2025 (IOM, 2025).

To better understand the impact of displacement on agricultural activities, food security and the assistance needs of IDPs, FAO conducted a DIEM-Monitoring CATI survey between 31 October and 14 November 2025. Based on available contacts, the survey targeted two regions – Mopti and Ségou – and the sample was stratified by type of residence (in or outside camps). A total of 247 households were interviewed (195 in Mopti and 52 in Ségou), covering 14 of the 15 districts in these two regions. Of these households, 49 percent live in camps or similar sites, and 51 percent live outside camps. Mopti and Ségou occupy a central place in the dynamics of internal displacement. In September 2025, they were, respectively, the first (37 400 households) and third (18 500 households) regions in terms of hosting displaced households (IOM, 2025). The results obtained are indicative and exploratory as the sample is not statistically representative of IDPs in the Mopti and Ségou regions.

Mopti has been a host region since 2012, following the arrival of IDPs from northern Mali. Its geographical location on the route to the south makes it a strategic area. Since 2018, the region has also become a source area of displacement due to the spread of violence perpetrated by armed groups and intercommunal tensions related to access to natural resources – land and water. Part of the population has been forced to seek refuge in urban centres or other host communities located nearby.

Although affected by conflict, the Ségou region is generally considered less dangerous than Mopti or Ménaka, which explains the arrival of IDPs seeking areas perceived as relatively safer (ACAPS, 2024).

In terms of agricultural production, the Mopti region, situated between the Sahelian and Sahelian-Sudanese agroecological zones, is characterized by a prevalence of agropastoral farming systems, flood-recession agriculture in the inland delta of the Niger River (rice and sorghum), and transhumant livestock farming (cattle, sheep and goats). The region is experiencing changing climatic conditions (lower and more irregular rainfall) and a strong dependence on flooding of the Niger River.

Located in the Sudanese-Saharan zone, the Ségou region is distinguished by its diversified agricultural systems, combining rainfed crops (millet, sorghum and maize), irrigated rice and cash crops, such as cotton. Thanks to significant hydroagricultural infrastructure and the predominance of settled family farms, it is among the most productive agricultural areas in the country.

Results

Deterioration of livelihoods due to conflict-related economic pressures

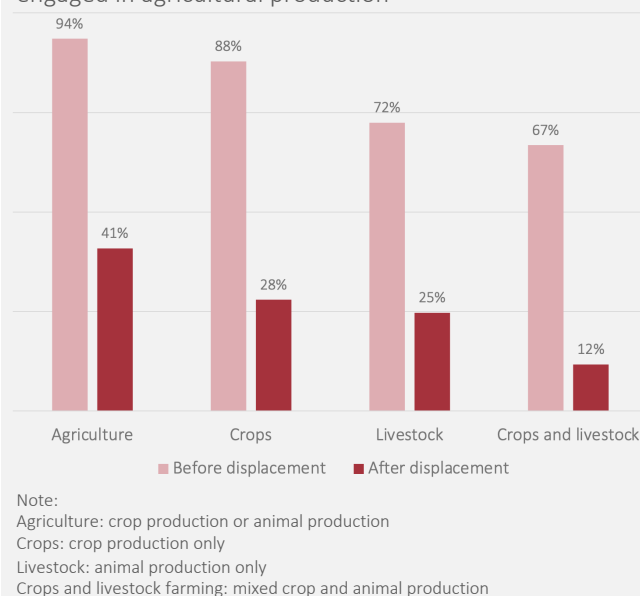
Eighty percent of surveyed households have resided in the survey area for at least three years, reflecting the protracted nature of displacement. Conflict and insecurity are cited as the primary reasons for displacement (99 percent).

However, during the survey, direct exposure to recent conflict events appears to be limited: only 11 percent of surveyed households reported having been exposed to conflict in the year preceding the survey, and 2 percent reported violence over the three months preceding the survey. Nevertheless, conflict and insecurity indirectly affect the livelihoods of IDPs, particularly due to economic consequences such as increased food prices (28 percent) and reduced income opportunities (19 percent).

The central role of agriculture in the livelihoods of IDPs

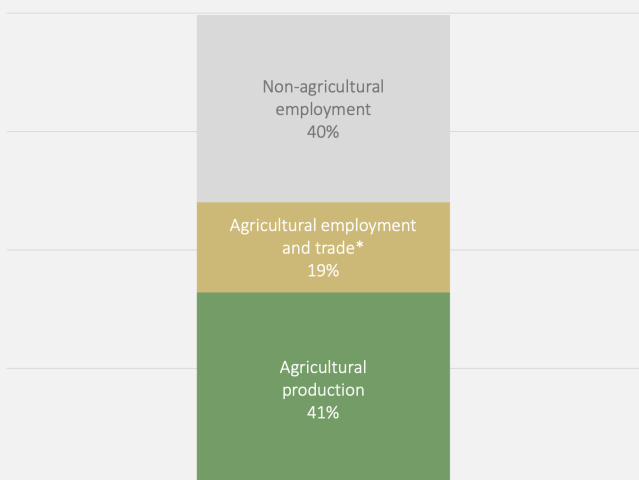
Before displacement, almost all displaced households (94 percent) were engaged in agricultural production activities – crop production (88 percent), livestock farming (72 percent) and mixed crop-livestock systems (67 percent). Post-displacement, 56 percent of farming households ceased agricultural production activities. Only 41 percent of surveyed displaced households reported engaging in agricultural activity over the year preceding the survey – 28 percent engaged in crop production and 25 percent in livestock farming. Among these, 12 percent were engaged in mixed systems – implying an overall decrease in agricultural production (Figure 2).

Figure 2. Percentage of internally displaced households engaged in agricultural production



Source: FAO. 2026. DIEM-Monitoring. In: *DIEM Hub*. Rome.
 [Cited 6 April 2026]. <https://data-in-emergencies.fao.org/pages/monitoring>

Figure 3. Main sources of income reported by internally displaced households



* Excluding own production

Source: FAO, 2026. DIEM-Monitoring. In: *DIEM Hub*, Rome. [Cited 6 April 2026]. <https://data-in-emergencies.fao.org/pages/monitoring>

The median cultivated area among displaced households is 1 hectare and three-quarters cultivate no more than 2 hectares. This population cultivates crops typical of the area. The main crops cited² are millet (39 percent), rice (22 percent), sorghum (10 percent), beans (10 percent) and groundnuts (7 percent), in addition to vegetables in smaller quantities. None of the surveyed displaced households primarily cultivate maize, although it is the leading crop nationally (29 percent) (FAO, 2025).

Sheep (57 percent), goats (23 percent) and cattle (18 percent) are the main livestock species raised – poultry was not mentioned. The median number of animals kept is 3 for goats and sheep, and 2 for cattle.

Some displaced households that were not engaged in agricultural production over the year preceding the survey continue to depend on the agriculture sector. Excluding IDPs directly involved in agricultural production, 19 percent of IDPs reported a primary source of income from this sector over the three months preceding the survey. These are mainly permanent or seasonal agricultural workers and, to a lesser extent, agricultural traders. These figures reflect a shift among some displaced farmers from producing their own food to wage labour in agriculture, and the persistence of a strong economic link with the agriculture sector.

Despite the decline in involvement in agricultural production, it remains an essential livelihood source for displaced households. Sixty percent depend on the agriculture sector, either through production or the income it generates, making the agriculture sector a key economic pillar for these populations.

² Only one main crop cited per household.

Land access and return to agricultural activity

Access to land and water appears to be the main factor limiting the return to agricultural activities. More than half (52 percent) of those engaged in agricultural production before displacement report not having access to land or water. Additional reported barriers include the high cost of land (40 percent) – whether rented or purchased – land scarcity (32 percent), insecurity (24 percent) and restrictions imposed by authorities (14 percent) (Figure 4).

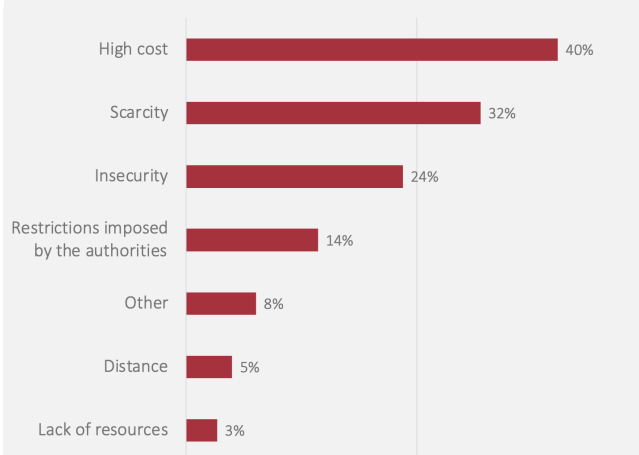
Limited access to land and water does not fully explain the inability of some IDPs to resume agricultural production. Some displaced farmers without access to land continue to engage in agricultural production (18 percent). On the other hand, among displaced farming households reporting access to land and water at the time of the survey, 28 percent indicated they were not involved in agricultural production. Other factors limit the resumption of agricultural activity or encourage households to turn to different activities after displacement.

The analysis revealed that IDPs living outside camps were more likely to engage in agriculture (48 percent) than those residing in camps (34 percent) – even with comparable levels of predisplacement agricultural engagement, access to farmland and assistance.

Food insecurity

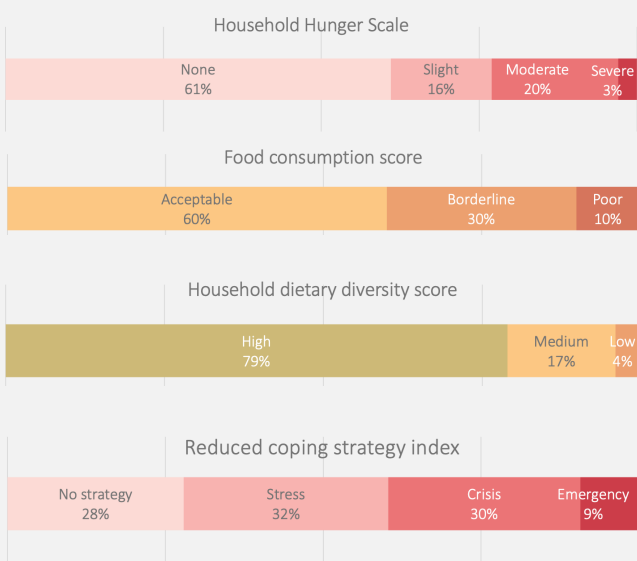
An estimated 23 percent of internally displaced households face acute food insecurity requiring assistance (Integrated Food Security Phase Classification Phase 3 or above). Forty percent have inadequate food consumption, indicating a poor or borderline food consumption score (FCS), and the use of Crisis or Emergency livelihood coping strategies (Figure 5).

Figure 4. Main barriers to accessing land and water among internally displaced households



Source: FAO, 2026. DIEM-Monitoring. In: *DIEM Hub*, Rome. [Cited 6 April 2026]. <https://data-in-emergencies.fao.org/pages/monitoring>

Figure 5. Food insecurity indicators



Source: FAO. 2026. DIEM-Monitoring. In: *DIEM Hub*. Rome. [Cited 6 April 2026]. <https://data-in-emergencies.fao.org/pages/monitoring>

These estimates should, however, be considered with caution. The survey was conducted during the harvest season, a time when food availability is generally higher and needs are lower. The need for assistance is, therefore, greater during the rest of the year, particularly the lean season.

This interpretation aligns with the needs expressed by households, which are significantly higher than estimates based on food security indicators. Ninety-nine percent of the surveyed households reported needing assistance to cover their food and financial needs over the six months following the survey.

Needs and assistance

The most frequently reported needs are food assistance (66 percent) and support for agricultural livelihoods (24 percent). Among households expressing agricultural needs, food assistance (73 percent), agricultural input vouchers or fairs (72 percent), and, to a lesser extent, crop inputs (31 percent), were the most frequently cited. These results highlight the predominance of food needs, the strong link between food assistance and support for agricultural production, and a preference for market-based interventions, particularly through vouchers.

Among displaced farmers unable to resume agricultural activity, the demand for agricultural support is significantly higher among those without access to land (29 percent) than among those with access (8 percent). This underscores the importance of integrating land access into support programmes and argues for greater inclusion of landless IDPs in these support mechanisms.

In terms of coverage, 36 percent of IDPs reported receiving assistance, almost exclusively in the form of food assistance. This percentage is broadly consistent with the needs identified by food security indicators.

The level of food security between households receiving and not receiving food assistance did not differ significantly. However, the available data do not indicate whether this resulted from effective targeting of households with the greatest needs, or from a limited effect of the assistance provided.

Finally, households involved in agricultural activities appear to be less exposed to food insecurity, although this advantage remains modest. These households exhibit lower levels of severe hunger and slightly higher household dietary diversity than those not engaged in agriculture. However, the differences observed in FCS and coping strategies between the two groups are not statistically significant, suggesting that agricultural activity alone is insufficient to improve the food consumption of displaced households.

Implications for programmes

The results of the DIEM-Monitoring survey suggest a need to adapt livelihood support programmes to target internally displaced populations in the central regions of Mali:

- Food assistance and livelihood support remain essential for a significant portion of these populations given the observed levels of food insecurity.
- Crucial to improving the living conditions of IDPs, agriculture must be central to strategies for supporting and restoring livelihoods as evidenced by the needs expressed.
- However, agriculture is sometimes excluded from assistance programmes on the grounds of limited access to land or the supposedly temporary nature of displacement. Yet, in a context of prolonged displacement, a partial resumption of agricultural activities has been observed. Former farmers without access to land have requested agricultural support and should receive the appropriate assistance.
- Agricultural support programmes should always include mechanisms for accessing land and water, which are the main, though not only, obstacles to returning to agricultural production.
- For households unable to resume farming as their own activity, agricultural wage labour and the development of income-generating activities in the agriculture sector should be considered.
- The needs for food assistance and agricultural support are closely linked. Interventions must take this reality into account to improve food security and the resilience of IDPs in Mali.

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